

THE BJP TROIKA
Prime Minister Narendra Modi with BJP national president J.P. Nadda and Union home minister Amit Shah, Dec. 7

are, therefore, a reality." With Modi at the helm, the party leadership is confident that an overhaul will contribute to consolidation and continuity in the 2024 polls. Winning the assembly elections in the three states has given the party much-needed affirmation that the changes are working, and for the good.

Experience and electoral debacles have taught the BJP that keeping the caste matrix in mind and making course corrections are crucial exercises in realpolitik. The BJP leadership wanted to change CMs in four states back in 2018—Raghubar Das in Jharkhand, besides Chouhan, Raman Singh and Raje—to cut down anti-incumbency. But they relented apprehending a crisis in leadership. The outcome was the party losing power in all four states. It was a dilemma the Congress had grappled with too. It wanted to opt for a younger leadership in Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh in 2018, but eventually opted for the old guard. They have paid the price—by losing Jyotiraditya Scindia to the BJP and facing defeat in Rajasthan now.

The BJP, however, learned from its mistakes. Gaining in confidence after the victory in the 2019 Lok Sabha election, the party changed strategy. It started with Bihar, where they pulled out a satrap of 25 years, Sushil Kumar Modi, after the National Democratic Alliance posted a victory. The party demonstrated the same ruthlessness in changing CMs in Assam, Uttarakhand, Gujarat, Tripura and Karnataka, but stopped short of doing the same in Madhya Pradesh. Chouhan remained at the helm even though he was dropped from the parliamentary board last September. The change in Karnataka, where the stalwart B.S. Yediyurappa was replaced by the lightweight Basavaraj Bommai, backfired, sending the BJP in the state tumbling into a leadership crisis. Now, the BJP has gone back to the Yediyurappa family, appointing his son B.Y. Vijayendra as the state unit chief and clipping the wings of his bete noire, B.L. Santhosh. Not that these moves will be without their concomitant risks but, then, facing them is an element of any switch in strategy.

It is something that the Congress got so right in Telangana even when it got everything so wrong elsewhere, exposing it to the ignominy of being in power in just three states—Himachal Pradesh, Karnataka and now Telangana. It put its weight behind Reddy, a man who had journeyed through other parties in the Opposition before joining the Congress in 2017, becoming a working president and then the Telangana Pradesh Congress chief in 2021 to lead the party into electoral battle. With his aggressive approach, Reddy took the fight right into the enemy camp, following the fiats of the party's central leadership, which positioned poll strategist Sunil Kanugolu to assess the chances of aspirants before handing them tickets, and finally managed to win with a slender majority of 64 in the 119-seat assembly.

Instead of falling back on the trusted old guard in Telangana, the Congress decided to live up to its slogan 'Maarpu Kaavali, Congress Raavali' (Change is needed, the Congress should come) and picked Reddy to become chief minister and Mallu Bhatti Vikramarka, from among the Scheduled Castes, to be his deputy. If only the Grand Old Party could show such foresightedness across the country. The BJP may yet have something to fight against. ■

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while plans for Chouhan and Raje are expected to be unveiled soon. They will be by no means easy decisions for Chouhan and Raje to accept—while both of them welcomed the decision on the face of it, their facial expressions told entirely different stories. They have yet to reveal what they plan to do next. Both remain popular among the cadre and masses, and pulled their weight to ensure victory for the BJP in the elections in their respective states.

MAKING OF A NEW BJP

The installation of new faces as chief ministers in states could also be a cue for introducing similar drastic changes in contestants for the coming general election. The BJP already has 17 sitting MPs who are more than 75 years old—the unspoken retirement age in the party when you move from electoral politics to an honorary membership of the 'margdarshak mandal'—and 42 others above 70. "After multiple terms, a fatigue factor develops even in the case of the popular and accomplished," says another top BJP leader. "Changes